

Stefan H. Thomke

Experimentation Works & the Business of Testing

William Barclay Harding Professor of Business Administration · Harvard Business School

[portrait]

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1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Thomke shows that the organisations winning today run thousands of disciplined experiments. His work is why Unit 9 treats testing not as a final check but as a core capability and culture — the engine of evidence-based innovation.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

German-American professor at Harvard Business School and a leading authority on innovation and experimentation. His research documents how firms build large-scale experimentation capabilities and cultures that make testing routine.

“Nearly any company can run experiments; few have a culture of experimentation.”

“To have a great idea, have a lot of them — and test them.”

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Experimentation as capability	Testing as a scalable organisational competence
Controlled experiments	Rigorous cause-and-effect testing at scale
Experimentation culture	Leadership, tools and norms that enable testing
Learning economics	The value of cheap, fast, frequent experiments
Enlightened experimentation	Designing experiments that maximise learning

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Lower the cost and time of each experiment
- Build tools and platforms for large-scale testing
- Cultivate a culture that welcomes surprising results
- Insist decisions rest on experimental evidence
- Design experiments to maximise learning per trial

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Large-scale testing needs traffic and infrastructure
- Over-testing can fragment strategy and vision
- Ethical limits on experimenting with users
- Short-term metrics may crowd out long-term bets
- Culture change is slow and leadership-dependent

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- *Experimentation Works* a definitive text on the topic
- Advised major firms on experimentation capability
- Reframed testing as strategic, not tactical
- Bridged academic rigour and business practice
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 9 testing culture

SELECTED WORKS

EXPERIMENTATION WORKS

The Surprising Power of Business Experiments

THOMKE · 2020

EXPERIMENTATION MATTERS

Unlocking the Potential of New Technologies

THOMKE · 2003

MANAGING PRODUCT AND SERVICE DEVELOPMENT

cases & readings

THOMKE · 2006

BUILDING A CULTURE OF EXPERIMENTATION

Harvard Business Review

THOMKE · 2020

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Thomke, S.H. (2020) *Experimentation Works*. Boston: Harvard Business Review Press.

Thomke, S.H. (2020) 'Building a Culture of Experimentation', *Harvard Business Review*, 98(2), pp. 40–47.